insisted that the letter from Amanullah needed to be understood in light of ‘Afghan psychology’. He explained:

We can, of course, vanquish Afghanistan, but only at a cost of prolongation of war with its attendant dangers – probable breakdown of stable Government in Afghanistan, thereby opening Afghan doors to Bolshevism, probably necessitating occupation of parts of the country by our troops...Bolshevik propaganda skilfully manipulated from Tashkend [sic] is preaching that we are bent upon an aggressive war on one of the few remaining Moslem powers. Had we resumed hostilities after the Amir had fulfilled our demand [for a ceasefire]...we feel that this would have been [the] interpretation placed on our action by the Moslem world...[150]

The alternative to accepting the armistice, in the opinion of the Indian government, would have meant continued military action and the weakening of Afghanistan. This would subsequently result either in exposing that country to Bolshevism or of having to make it a British protectorate, a prospect nobody relished. As the secretary of the Military Department of the India Office, Lieutenant-General Sir Vaughan Cox, aptly put it, ‘I cannot imagine a less profitable country to “protect” than Afghanistan – a veritable wasps’ nest.’[151]

This was, of course, assuming that India would continue to be victorious should the conflict resume. The Third Anglo-Afghan War had, in fact, highlighted the weaknesses in the Indian army following the First World War. Not only were its numbers depleted, but those soldiers who remained were often undisciplined and inexperienced in frontier fighting. The Indian troops faced a hard enemy in the tough and skilled tribesmen who had joined the war with Afghan encouragement,[152] and there was a genuine fear that should the conflict resume, India might not be able to defeat Afghanistan, at least not as quickly and resoundly as should be expected from the larger power.[153] It was also clear that a speedy resolution to the current crisis was in the interest of India’s domestic concerns. The scars of the Amritsar Massacre were yet to heal, and Gandhi’s nationalist agitation